

Fate's Edge

Condensed Rules Reference

A short digest for players and GMs

Core rules only. Advanced options (Patrons, assets, travel decks, high-tier play) are in the full guides.

© 2026. Free to share under CC BY 4.0.

May 14, 2026

Contents

1	Introduction	3
1.1	Core Philosophy & Safety	3
1.1.1	Narrative First	3
1.1.2	Golden Rule	3
1.1.3	Safety Tools	3
1.2	The 90-Second Play Loop	3
2	Dice, Outcomes, and Resources	4
2.1	Dice Pool	4
2.2	Outcome Matrix	4
2.3	Boons (Player Resource)	4
2.4	Story Beat (GM Resource)	5
2.5	Position and Difficulty Value (DV)	5
2.5.1	Position	5
2.5.2	Difficulty Value (DV)	5
3	Combat, Harm, and Healing	6
3.1	Combat in Brief	6
3.1.1	Actions	6
3.1.2	Combat Clocks	6
3.2	Harm and Fatigue	6
3.2.1	Fatigue Track	6
3.2.2	Harm Levels	7
3.2.3	Taking Harm (Procedure)	7
3.2.4	Armor Conversion	7
3.2.5	Recovery	7
4	Player-Managed Resources	8
5	Magic in One Page	9
5.1	Free Caster (Spellcraft)	9
5.1.1	Sample Spells	9
5.1.2	Elemental Backlash (Minor)	9
6	Clocks and Pressure	10
6.1	Three-Clock Guideline (per scene)	10
6.2	Mandate & Crisis (Campaign Clocks)	10

7	GM Quick Reference	11
7.1	Default Settings	11
7.2	SB Spend Menu	11
7.3	Outcome Reminders	11
7.4	Combat Quick Ref	11
7.5	Travel Clocks (optional)	11
8	Player Reference	12
8.1	Your Turn	12
8.2	Spending Boons	12
8.3	Bonded Actions	12
8.4	Healing Yourself	12
9	Example Play (Condensed)	13
10	Quick Build & Advancement	14
10.1	Starting Characters (30 XP)	14
10.2	Advancement per Session (typical)	14
10.3	Spending XP	14
10.4	Rush Rule	15
11	Common Rolls & Synergies	16
11.1	Default Pairs	16
11.2	Assist Limit	16
11.3	Selling the Action (GM may grant +1 Position or bank a Boon)	16
12	Core Tables	17
13	Glossary	18

1 Introduction

1.1 Core Philosophy & Safety

1.1.1 Narrative First

Mechanics serve the story. Describe what you do; the dice decide how it goes wrong or right.

1.1.2 Golden Rule

When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default: **Difficulty Value (DV)** 3, **Position** Controlled (see section [2.5](#)).

1.1.3 Safety Tools

Use **Lines** (content that never appears), **Veils** (content that happens off-screen), and **X-Card** (stop and rewind any moment). The GM is also a player.

1.2 The 90-Second Play Loop

Step 1: Player declares intent – “I want to X by doing Y.”

Step 2: GM sets Position and Difficulty Value (DV) – Risk (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) and Difficulty (2–5+).

Step 3: Player rolls – Attribute + Skill d10s.

Step 4: Count successes (6+) and **Story Beat** (1s).

Step 5: Apply Outcome – see section [2.2](#).

Step 6: GM spends Story Beat – complications, clocks, scene shifts (see section [2.4](#)).

Step 7: Pass the spotlight – next player acts.

2 Dice, Outcomes, and Resources

2.1 Dice Pool

Dice pool = Attribute + Skill (both 1–5, starting max 3). Success = die showing 6–10. A **10** counts as two successes. **Story Beat** = die showing 1. The GM gains one SB for each 1 rolled.

2.2 Outcome Matrix

Result	Criteria	What Happens	Player Gains	GM Gains
Clean Success	Successes $\geq$ Difficulty Value (DV) , SB = 0	Intent achieved, no complication	–	–
Success with SB	Successes $\geq$ Difficulty Value (DV) , SB > 0	Intent achieved, GM adds twist	–	SB as rolled
Partial	$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{Difficulty Value (DV)}$	Progress made, situation unresolved	1 Boons	SB as rolled
Miss	Successes = 0	No progress, situation escalates	2 Boons	SB as rolled

Important: **Story Beat** are generated on the roll, not after re-rolls. Re-rolling a 1 does not remove the SB.

2.3 Boons(Player Resource)

- Hold up to 5 **Boons**. At scene end, reduce to 2 (excess lost).
- **Spend 1 Boons to:** re-roll a die (after seeing pool); improve **Position** by one step (before rolling); activate an **Asset**; or power certain abilities.
- **Earn Boons:** Partial (1), Miss (2), **Bond**-driven action (once per **Bond** per session), GM award.
- **Convert to XP:** 2 **Boons** → 1 XP, once per session, max 2 XP.

2.4 Story Beat(GM Resource)

SB Cost	Effect
1	Minor: noise, trace, +1 segment on a Clock
2	Moderate: alarm raised, lose advantage, lesser foe appears
3	Serious: reinforcements, key gear breaks, tick a front Clock
4+	Major: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts

2.5 Position and Difficulty Value (DV)

2.5.1 Position

Position = risk. Set by fiction (cover, surprise, danger).

Position	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	May re-roll one failure
Controlled	No re-rolls (default)
Desperate	Must re-roll one success (keep second result)

2.5.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

How hard the task is. Default = 3.

DV	When to Use
2	Routine, no pressure
3	Pressured, mild opposition
4	Difficult, active resistance
5+	Extreme, high stakes

GM advice: Do not inflate **Difficulty Value (DV)** to challenge players. Use **Position**, **Clocks**, and **SB** instead.

3 Combat, Harm, and Healing

3.1 Combat in Brief

- **Initiative:** Narrative – GM spotlights based on fiction. Ambushes act first.
- **Turn:** Move (one range band) + Action (attack, cast, defend, etc.). No fixed rounds.
- **Range Bands:** Close → Near → Far → Absent.
- **Opportunity Attack:** Leaving Close range without using Disengage provokes one free melee attack.

3.1.1 Actions

Action	Effect
Attack	Melee/ranged attack
Disengage	Move without provoking opportunity attacks
Charge (full turn)	Move two bands + melee attack; costs 1 Fatigue; next defense Desperate
Defend	Improve Position by one step for defense; protect allies
Assist	Spend 1 Boons to give +1 die to ally (max +3 from all assists)

3.1.2 Combat Clocks

Use visible **Clocks** for enemy morale [6], environmental danger [4], boss phases.

3.2 Harm and Fatigue

3.2.1 Fatigue Track

- Each character has Fatigue = Body rating.
- Each Fatigue worsens **Position**: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate.
- If already Desperate, each Fatigue gives –1 die instead.
- **Full track:** Increase Harm by 1 step, clear all Fatigue.

3.2.2 Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	−1 die on related actions
Harm 2	−1 die on most actions until treated
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying

3.2.3 Taking Harm (Procedure)

1. Convert incoming Harm to Fatigue using armor (see table 3.2.4).
2. Apply remaining Harm – if any Harm remains, increase Harm level and clear all existing Fatigue (the shock resets exhaustion).
3. Add converted Fatigue; if track fills, overflow triggers Harm increase.

3.2.4 Armor Conversion

Armor	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

3.2.5 Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest (1 hour) clears 2; full night's rest clears all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care and time (downtime). Magical healing exists but has costs (see section 5.1).

4 Player-Managed Resources

Players track their own:

- **Obligation**(per Patron or Symbol) – Capacity = Spirit + Presence. Exceeding capacity causes 1 Fatigue per segment over.
- **Corruption** clock (Cantors)
- Leash clock (Summoners)
- **Asset** states (Maintained / Neglected / Compromised)
- **Follower** conditions (Exposure, Harm)
- Fatigue and Harm
- **Boons**

Player duties: Mark immediately when a rule says “mark +X”. Declare thresholds (“My **Obligation** is full!”). Keep trackers visible to the table.

GM duties: Spot-check occasionally. Enforce thresholds (e.g., **Obligation** overflow → Fatigue). Own the fallout (Patron intrusions, faction reactions).

5 Magic in One Page

5.1 Free Caster (Spellcraft)

Requires **Spellcraft** talent (6 XP). No Patron.

- **Casting:** Describe spell using **TAGS**. **Difficulty Value (DV)** = 1 + number of tags. Dangerous tags (Teleport, Transform, Dominate) add +2 **Difficulty Value (DV)**.
- **Roll:** Wits + Arcana.
- **Backlash (on Miss or GM spending SB):** Choose one: Harm 2 (arcane), +2 Fatigue, **Corruption** +1, or catastrophic side effect (GM describes).

5.1.1 Sample Spells

Spell	TAGS	DV
Light a candle	[ILLUMINATE]	2
Mend Fatigue	[HEAL]	2
Shield of Air	[WARD] [DE-FEND]	3
Flame Cloak	[BURNING] [AREA]	3
Wall of Stone	[BARRIER] [FORTIFY]	3 (or 4 if dangerous)

5.1.2 Elemental Backlash (Minor)

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks
Water	Slick floor, damp
Earth	Dust, tremor
Air	Gust, ringing ears
Fate	Option closes
Luck	Small misfortune
Life	Overgrowth
Death	Chill whispers

(Major backlash tables in full guide.)

6 Clocks and Pressure

Clocks are visible trackers for threats, progress, and looming changes.

Size: 4 (short scene), 6 (standard), 8 (arc), 10 (epic). **Name them clearly:** “Alarm Raised [4]” not “Bad Stuff”. **Advance a Clock:** on a Miss, certain Partial, or when GM spends SB.

6.1 Three-Clock Guideline (per scene)

- **Immediate Clock** – what’s about to go wrong (e.g., Collapsing Bridge [4])
- **Situational Clock** – pressure shaping decisions (e.g., Crowd Turns Hostile [6])
- **Long-term Clock** – echoes forward (e.g., Faction Retaliation [8])

6.2 Mandate & Crisis (Campaign Clocks)

- **Mandate (0–6)** – party’s public legitimacy. High = doors open; low = suspicion.
- **Crisis (0–6)** – opposition’s growing strength. High = enemies strike boldly.

7 GM Quick Reference

7.1 Default Settings

- **Difficulty Value (DV)**= 3
- **Position**= Controlled
- One short **Clock** per scene

7.2 SB Spend Menu

(see section [2.4](#))

7.3 Outcome Reminders

(see section [2.2](#))

7.4 Combat Quick Ref

(see section [3.1](#) and [3.2](#))

7.5 Travel Clocks (optional)

- 4 segments: short leg
- 6 segments: standard leg
- 8 segments: extended journey
- 10 segments: epic passage

8 Player Reference

8.1 Your Turn

1. Declare intent and approach (Attribute + Skill)
2. GM tells you **Position** and **Difficulty Value (DV)**
3. Roll dice, count successes (6+) and 1s (SB for GM)
4. Apply outcome (GM will tell you Clean/Success with SB/Partial/Miss)
5. Mark **Boons** (1 on Partial, 2 on Miss) and any Fatigue/Harm
6. If you rolled 1s, GM may spend SB immediately

8.2 Spending Boons

(see section [2.3](#))

8.3 Bonded Actions

- Once per **Bond** per session: when you help a bonded ally with an intricate description, both gain 1 **Boons** after the action.
- At Tier II+ (41+ XP), you may transfer up to 2 **Boons** to a bonded ally as a free action (once per scene).

8.4 Healing Yourself

(see section [3.2](#))

9 Example Play (Condensed)

From Blood and Silk – negotiation scene.

Marcus: “I step forward, hand on sword. ‘Garrick, name a price that doesn’t starve children.’ Presence + Command.”

GM: “Controlled, **Difficulty Value (DV)** 3.”

Marcus rolls: 6,8,3,1,1 → 2 successes, 2 SB → Partial ($2 < 3$). Gains 1 **Boons**.

GM: “Garrick listens. ‘500 silver and a wagon of seed grain.’ I spend 1 SB: a farmer shouts ‘Kill them!’ **Tick Village Panic** +1. I spend the other SB: Vex whispers to Garrick and eyes Elena – her next action is Desperate.”

Sariel: “I slip behind Vex. Wits + Stealth.”

GM: “Controlled, **Difficulty Value (DV)** 3.”

Sariel rolls: 2,4,5,6,10 → 3 successes ($10 = 2$) → Clean Success.

GM: “You tap her elbow. ‘Don’t.’ She freezes. Your next action against her is Dominant.”

... and so on.

10 Quick Build & Advancement

10.1 Starting Characters (30 XP)

- **Attributes:** each starts at 1. Raise to 2 (6 XP), 3 (9 XP), etc. (new rating $\times 3$ XP)
- **Skills:** start at 0. Raise to 1 (2 XP), 2 (4 XP), etc. (new level $\times 2$ XP)
- **Minor Asset (4 XP):** safehouse, contact, special tool
- **Minor Talent (2–3 XP):** Keen Senses, Second Wind, etc.
- **Bonds (up to 2, +2 XP each)**
- **Complications (up to 2, +2 XP each)** – each unresolved adds +1 banked SB to early scenes.

10.2 Advancement per Session (typical)

- Attendance: +2 XP
- Major objectives: +2–4 XP
- Discoveries: +1–2 XP
- Hard choices: +1–2 XP
- Personal goals: +1–2 XP

10.3 Spending XP

Improvement	Cost	Downtime
Attribute	new rating $\times 3$ XP	new rating days
Skill	new level $\times 2$ XP	new level days
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month
Minor Talent	2–3 XP	—
Major Talent	4–6 XP	scene of training
Prestige Talent	7–10 XP	Tier II+ & narrative

10.4 Rush Rule

Skip downtime by accepting a Haste **Clock** [4]. If it fills before you finish, the new ability has a flaw.

11 Common Rolls & Synergies

11.1 Default Pairs

Action	Standard Pair	Alternative
Climb a wall	Body + Athletics	Wits + Athletics (route-finding)
Persuade a guard	Presence + Sway	Wits + Sway (logical argument)
Investigate a crime	Wits + Investigation	Spirit + Investigation (intuition)
Cast a spell	Wits + Arcana	Spirit + Arcana (willpower)

11.2 Assist Limit

Max +3 dice from all assists per roll. One **Follower** may assist (adds min(Cap, relevant skill) dice).

11.3 Selling the Action (GM may grant +1 Position or bank a Boon)

- **Counts:** stating a clear stake, invoking a **Bond**, revealing a fear, making a hard choice visible.
- **Does not count:** piling on adjectives, passive sensory lists, repeated descriptions.

12 Core Tables

(Repeated for easy reference – see sections [2.2](#), [2.5](#), [2.3](#), [3.2](#), [3.2.4](#).)

13 Glossary

- **Asset** – Off-screen resource (safehouse, spy network, workshop). Costs XP. Can be activated with 1 **Boons**.
- **Bond** – Mutual connection between two PCs. Once per session, when you help your bonded ally with intricate description, both gain 1 **Boons**.
- **Boons** – Player resource earned on Partial and Misses. Spend to re-roll, improve Position, activate Assets.
- **Cap** – Follower capability rating (1–5). Adds min(Cap, skill) dice when assisting.
- **Clock** – Visible progress tracker (4/6/8/10 segments). Advances on Misses, Partial, or SB spends.
- **Compromised** – State of an Asset or Symbol: unusable until repaired.
- **Corruption** – Cantor resource. Clock fills → gain Patron’s burden/benefit, reset to Tier minimum.
- **Crisis** – Campaign clock (0–6). High = enemies stronger.
- **Difficulty Value (DV)** – Target number of successes. Default 3.
- **Exposure** – Follower stress track. Leads to Neglected/Compromised.
- **Fatigue** – Exhaustion track. Worsens Position; full track → Harm+1, clear Fatigue.
- **Follower** – Named NPC ally. Costs Cap² XP. Can assist or take independent actions.
- **Harm** – Injury track (1–3). Imposes die penalties.
- **Leash** – Summoner’s control track. When full, spirit acts independently.
- **Mandate** – Campaign clock (0–6). High = party is respected.
- **Miss** – 0 successes. Player gains 2 **Boons**; GM gains SB and escalates.
- **Neglected** – State of Asset or Follower: –1 die until attention given.
- **Obligation** – Debt to Patron (or terrestrial patron). Capacity = Spirit + Presence. Over capacity → Fatigue.
- **Partial** – 0 < successes < DV. Player gains 1 **Boons**; GM gains SB.

- **Patron** – Cosmic entity granting Rites. Runkeeper = Obligation; Invoker = Symbol; Cantor = Corruption.
- **Position** – Risk level: Dominant (safe), Controlled (normal), Desperate (dangerous).
- **Story Beat (SB)** – GM resource. Earned on any 1. Spent to create complications.
- **String** – Narrative leverage (favor owed, secret known). Can be spent like currency.
- **TAGS** – Keywords for freeform magic (e.g., [FIRE], [AREA], [MEND]). DV = 1 + number of tags.
- **Terrestrial Patron** – Mortal faction offering aid in exchange for Debt Clock.
- **Thiasos** – Familiar/token for Runekeepers (2 XP). Required for Patron's Gift.
- **XP** – Experience Points. Earned at session end. Spent on Attributes, Skills, Assets, Talents.

Index

Asset, [3](#), [7](#), [13](#), [17](#)

Bond, [3](#), [11](#), [13](#), [15](#), [17](#)

Boons, [3](#), [5](#), [7](#), [11](#), [12](#), [17](#)

Cap, [17](#)

Clock, [4](#), [5](#), [9](#), [10](#), [14](#), [17](#)

Compromised, [17](#)

Corruption, [7](#), [8](#), [17](#)

Crisis, [17](#)

Difficulty Value (DV), [2–4](#), [8](#), [10–12](#), [17](#)

Exposure, [17](#)

Fatigue, [17](#)

Follower, [7](#), [15](#), [17](#)

Harm, [17](#)

Leash, [17](#)

Mandate, [17](#)

Miss, [17](#)

Neglected, [17](#)

Obligation, [7](#), [17](#)

Partial, [17](#)

Patron, [18](#)

Position, [2–5](#), [10](#), [11](#), [18](#)

Story Beat, [2–4](#)

Story Beat (SB), [18](#)

String, [18](#)

TAGS, [18](#)

Terrestrial Patron, [18](#)

Thiasos, [18](#)

XP, [18](#)